

A Short Note on Short Passives and French Reflexive *se*

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1.

When it comes to the binding of an anaphor by the agent phrase of a passive, French looks a lot like English if the reflexive or reciprocal is not a clitic. In English, we have:

(1) That letter will be sent to himself by John next week.

(2) These presents will be given to one another by the two students next week.

in which *himself* and *one another* are bound by *John* and *the two students*, respectively.

The French counterparts are as follows:

(3) Cette lettre sera expédiée à lui-même par Jean la semaine prochaine. ('that letter will-be sent to him-same by J the week next')

(4) Ces cadeaux seront offerts l'un à l'autre par les deux étudiants la semaine prochaine. ('these presents will-be given the-one to the-other by the two students the next week')

English and French are also similar in that both allow short passives in which no agent phrase is visible:

(5) John was sharply criticized last week.

(6) Jean a été vivement critiqué la semaine dernière. ('J has been sharply criticized the week last')

As discussed in Collins (2024, chap. 2), English short passives may contain a reflexive bound by the unpronounced agent, e.g.:

(7) Things like that should never be said about oneself in public.

French is again similar to English; in the following the French reflexive is *soi-même*:¹

(8) Des choses comme ça ne devraient pas/jamais être dites/offertes/expédiées à soi-même (pour aucune raison). ('des things like that neg. should not/never be said/given/sent to one-self (for any reason)')

2.

Against the background of the above similarities between French and English, the heart of this short note has to do with the fact that French has an additional anaphor, namely *se*, that lacks any close counterpart in English. French *se* is an object clitic that can be translated into English as either a reflexive or a reciprocal, depending on the surrounding syntactic environment.² Examples are:

(9) Jean s'est expédié une lettre. ('J *se* is/has sent a letter' = 'J sent himself a letter')

¹Cf. the colloquial German example given by Durrell (2002, 15.1.4(b)):

i) Jetzt wird sich gewaschen. ('now is reflex. washed')

translated there by *It's time to get washed*.

²Cf. Kayne (1975, chap. 5; 2018).

(10) Les deux étudiants se sont offerts des cadeaux. ('the two students se are/have given *des presents*' = 'the two students gave each other presents')
In these two examples, *se* suffices to convey a reflexive or reciprocal interpretation; it is also possible to have *se* cooccurring with a non-clitic reflexive or reciprocal:

(11) Jean s'est expédié une lettre à lui-même.

(12) Les deux étudiants se sont offerts des cadeaux l'un à l'autre.

3.

The key fact now is that French *se* can never take as antecedent the agent phrase in a passive, and this is so whether or not there is an additional non-clitic reflexive or reciprocal present. For reflexives, we can see this in the following example:

(13) *Cette lettre se sera expédiée (à lui-même) par Jean la semaine prochaine.
which is identical to (3), except that *se* has been added (and the non-clitic reflexive made optional). The contrast is striking; *se* can have as antecedent the thematic subject *Jean* in (11) when *Jean* is in Spec,IP, but not when *Jean* appears as the object of the agentive preposition *par* in (13).

This fact about *se* is illustrated for reciprocals in the following:

(14) *Ces cadeaux se seront offerts (l'un à l'autre) par les deux étudiants la semaine prochaine.

Reciprocal *se* cannot take as antecedent in (14) the thematic subject *les deux étudiants*, in sharp contrast to (12).

Summing up so far, the agent phrase in a passive in French can be the antecedent of a non-clitic reflexive or reciprocal, as in (3) and (4), but it can never be the antecedent of the clitic reflexive/reciprocal *se*, as seen in (13) and (14).

4.

The main point, now, is that this contrast in French between non-clitic anaphor and clitic anaphor carries over to short passives, despite there being in short passives no visible agent phrase. Example (8) illustrated the acceptability of a non-clitic reflexive taking the unpronounced agent of a short passive as antecedent. Having clitic *se* (or its reduced form *s'*) in a sentence like (8) is, however, sharply unacceptable, whether or not the non-clitic reflexive is present:³

(15) *Des choses comme ça ne devraient pas/jamais s'être dites/offertes/expédiées (à soi-même) (pour aucune raison).

The fact that short passives show the same incompatibility with clitic *se* as passives containing an overt agent phrase is hardly surprising if short passives syntactically contain an agent phrase, too (whose silence in short passives evidently has no effect on the binding facts in question).

If, on the other hand, short passives in French contained no syntactically present agent phrase, the sharp contrast between (8) and (15) and its resemblance to the facts of long passives would be at the very least difficult to understand.

5.

³The same holds for reciprocal instances of *se*, though minimal pairs are harder to come by than with reflexive *se*.

Open questions remain, as usual. A number of them are touched on in the remainder of this section. One concerns the restriction seen in (13)-(15). Why can *se* not have as antecedent either the silent or pronounced agent phrase of a passive? Possibly, this restriction is not specific to passives, insofar as *se* cannot have as antecedent a direct or indirect object, either. Put another way, it may be that the antecedent of *se* is subject, as a necessary (but not sufficient⁴) condition, to:

(16) The antecedent of *se* must be in Spec,IP (at some point in the derivation).
But even if (16) is correct, we still need to ask why it is, what it might in turn follow from.

Worth noting in passing is that it is clearly not the case that *se* must be preceded by its antecedent derivation-finally. This is shown by French causatives:⁵

(17) Cet éclairage fait *se* ressembler Jean et Marie-Claire. ('this lighting makes *se* resemble J and M-C')

(18) Elle voulait faire *se* laver les mains à ses enfants. ('she wanted to-make *se* wash the hands to her children')

In both of these examples, the antecedent of *se* follows it (*J and M-C*, in the first, *ses enfants* in the second). It is also shown by Stylistic Inversion⁶ examples such as:

(19) le jour où *se* sont critiqués les deux amis ('the day when *se* are/have criticized the two friends')

and by 'extraposition' examples such as:

(20) Il s'est dénoncé trois mille hommes ce mois-ci. ('it *se* is/has denounced three thousand men this month-here')

The condition stated in (16) implies that in all four of these examples the antecedent of *se* must have reached some Spec,IP prior to leftward movement of the verb past it.

Whether or not the restriction against *se* taking the agent phrase of a passive as antecedent should be generalized in the direction of (16) is not entirely certain. What I have in mind here is the fact the stranded quantifiers can also not be linked to a passive agent:

(21) That book should (*both) be read by the students.

Yet in this case the restriction does not fully extend to objects:

(22) You should read them all.

To be noted is that this restriction on stranded quantifiers extends to 'agent phrases' that do not, strictly speaking, contain agents:

(23) The teacher is (*all) liked by the students.

French, with certain such verbs, allows *de* ('of') to introduce the 'agent' (the usual agent-introducing preposition in French is *par* ('by')). A partially related question is that of 'agent phrases' with passives of unaccusatives, arguably as in:

(24) That question has already been gone into by tons of people.

Of general importance here is Noonan's (1993) proposal that "universally, stative and perfective verbs are unaccusative".

Somewhat different is the challenge posed by the agent preposition in derived nominals, as in:

(25) the destruction of the bridge by the enemy

⁴Cf. Rizzi (1986) for relevant discussion.

⁵Cf. Kayne (1975, chap. 6).

⁶Cf. Kayne and Pollock (2001).

which is the same as in sentential passives in English and French, but not in Italian or German.

Again in a different vein, we can note that agent phrases in passives can be deleted/silent only if the *by* is deleted, too:

(26) John is often criticized (*by).

Here, too, this may not be a restriction that is specific to passives, insofar as it resembles:

(27) I liked that book. The first chapter (*of) was especially interesting.

Finally, we can note that the very fact that clitic *se* acts differently from non-clitic anaphors (which are not subject to (16)) may itself not be specific to *se*. Here I have in mind a fact pointed out by Luigi Burzio (p.c.), namely that in Italian clitics and non-clitics act differently from each other with respect to overlapping reference:

(28) ?Consideriamo me intelligente. ('we-consider me intelligent')

(29) *Mi consideriamo intelligente. ('me we-consider intelligent')

With non-clitic *me*, (28) is marginal, but (29), with clitic *mi*, is sharply out.

6.

Despite the various open questions mentioned in the previous section, the overall conclusion seems inescapable. As in Collins (2024), going back at least to Chomsky (1957), short passives must contain a syntactically present deleted/silent agent.⁷

References:

Chomsky, N. (1957) *Syntactic Structures*, Mouton, The Hague.

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Rizzi, L. (1986) "On chain formation," in H. Borer (ed.) *Syntax and Semantics. Volume 19. The Syntax of Pronominal Clitics*, Academic Press, Orlando, 65-95.

⁷Keeping in mind the point made earlier about the term 'agent', and examples like:

i) John has not been heard from in quite a while.